Westbrook School Committee

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Thursday, July 30, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 117 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1214397757
Packet: No agenda was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org/page/westbrook-school-committee, 2026-10-24).

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Five of seven regular members were present (Katy Rice absent); no student representatives attended (one graduated, one on summer vacation). A brief special meeting for administrator appointments; every vote passed unanimously. Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Reports

Superintendent's Report [3:32]

Discussion Summary

Westbrook High School has moved from a three-co-principal leadership structure (in place for seven years) to a principal/two-assistant-principal structure: Jeff Garrett, previously a co-principal, moves into the principal role, and Patrick Colgan, also previously a co-principal, becomes an assistant principal — both internal transfers under the administrators' collective bargaining agreement. The second assistant principal role is filled by nomination later in this meeting (see 9.1.3 below).

The state's new bell-to-bell cell phone ban takes effect for the new school year; a community technology forum is planned for August 18 at Westbrook High School.

Greater Portland Metro, following advocacy from Mayor David Morse and the Westbrook Education Foundation, will provide free bus passes to Westbrook High School students, pending the City Council's second reading the following week — intended both to help students within the school's roughly 1.5-mile walking radius get to school, and to give students broader access to part-time jobs and Greater Portland destinations.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Chair's Remarks — Context on the Metro Bus Pass Initiative [8:48]

Discussion Summary

Chair Mancuso gave an extended reflection on how the bus-pass initiative came together, crediting two ad hoc transportation subcommittees, persistent advocacy from Principal Garrett and the high school team, and the district's chronically understaffed Transportation Department (fully staffed only once in the past six years, for less than a full year). She credited the Westbrook Education Foundation and City Hall for recognizing the

project's broader community transit value, not just its school-transportation benefit.

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

New Business

9.1.1 — Nomination of Bethany Connolly as Assistant Superintendent, First and Final Approval [15:23]

Discussion Summary
Moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Noreen Poitras. Cavallaro, who served on the hiring committee along with Dr. Flynn Ross, praised the strength of the candidate pool and Connolly's experience as principal of Skillin Elementary School in South Portland (nine years), noting demographic similarities to Sacarappa School. Dr. Lancia added that Connolly previously taught at and served as assistant principal of Lincoln Middle School. Connolly was not present (on an anniversary trip) and will be introduced in person at the August 12 meeting.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 6–0.

Action Items
None.

9.1.2 — Nomination of Tyler Pelletier as Assistant Principal, Westbrook Middle School, First and Final Approval [18:25]

Discussion Summary
Replaces Sam Chadow, who resigned. Moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Noreen Poitras. Pelletier, present at the meeting, introduced himself (seven years at South Portland Middle School and Dyer Elementary School).

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 6–0.

Action Items
None.

9.1.3 — Nomination of Carrie Fardella as Assistant Principal, Westbrook High School, First and Final Approval [20:31]

Discussion Summary
Added to the agenda by unanimous consent at the start of the meeting. Moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Noreen Poitras. Poitras, who served on the interview committee, praised Fardella's enthusiasm. Fardella, present and introduced by the Chair, said she was born and raised in Westbrook and has taught in the district for 34 years; she spoke about the day-to-day reality of students arriving at school with frozen feet from the 1.5-mile walk, tying directly back to the Metro bus pass initiative discussed above.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved 6–0.

Action Items

None.

> *“People at the high school, teachers, administrators, secretaries, custodians, we have change socks for kids whose feet are frozen from walking a mile and a half. We have a coat closet where there are boots that are dry and new socks that we can put on … this is a game changer for our school as far as attendance … this will level the playing field.”*

— Carrie Fardella [21:37]

Important Dates

Upcoming Meetings & Events [22:52]

Discussion Summary

August 12, 5:00 PM: Finance Committee resumes its monthly schedule (Room 114). August 12, 6:00 PM (earlier than usual, for this month only): regular School Committee meeting, immediately following Finance Committee, also Room 114. August 27–28: staff back-to-school days. August 31: first day of school for all students except kindergartners and preschoolers. The Chair also flagged the City Council's second and final reading on the Metro bus pass program, Monday, August 3 at 6:00 PM, and encouraged school-community members to attend in support.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Announcements

Back-to-School Information [25:23]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Lancia asked families to watch email, the district website, and social media for back-to-school information, including open house dates, and encouraged anyone in the community with a child who needs to register for school to contact registrar Mrs. Lentz at Westbrook High School over the summer.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Executive Session

9.2 — Adjourn Into Executive Session — Contract Negotiations [26:14]

Discussion Summary

Pursuant to 1 M.R.S.A. §405(6) (contract negotiations).

The committee adjourned directly from executive session with no further public action.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. No agenda or back-up packet was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org, 2026-10-24); this summary is drawn from the video/transcript alone. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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